

Galictis vittata

Greater grison



Length 18½–21½ in (47–55 cm)
Tail 5½–8 in (14–20 cm)
Weight 3¼–7½ lb (1.4–3.3 kg)
Location S. Mexico, Central and South America
Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Least concern



Even for a mustelid, the greater grison is long and sinuous, with a slim, pointed head and flexible neck; the tail, however, is relatively short. Coloration is all gray, other than a white, U-shaped stripe running across the forehead, passing just above each eye and over each ear, tapering toward the shoulder. There is also black below on the muzzle, throat, chest, and front legs. The grison lives alone or in a male–female pair, is an agile runner, swimmer, and climber, and eats various small animals (even worms) and fruit. Its sounds include snorts, growls, screams, and barks.



Ictonyx striatus

African zorilla



Location W. to E. and southern Africa



Length 11–15 in (28–38 cm)
Tail 6½–11 in (16.5–28 cm)
Weight 1–2½ lb (0.42–1.2 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Resembling a small skunk (see p.186), the zorilla (striped polecat) is jet black, other than 4 pure white stripes that fan out from the head, along the back and sides, to the tail base. The fluffy tail is mottled white and gray. If threatened, the zorilla hisses, screams, and raises its tail to spray noxious fluid from its anal glands. It digs with its long-clawed, front feet for grubs, mice, and other small creatures.

Gulo gulo

Wolverine



Location Canada, N.W. USA, N. Europe to N. and E. Asia



Length 26–41 in (65–105 cm)
Tail 8½–10 in (21–26 cm)
Weight 24–40 lb (11–18 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

The second biggest mustelid after the giant otter, the male wolverine is a third larger than the female. The species is stocky, strong, and bearlike, with extremely powerful jaws that can crunch frozen meat and bone of

caribou or similar carcasses in winter; parts of the carcass may be buried for later use. In addition to scavenging, the wolverine runs down victims even on soft snow, with its broad feet and muscular limbs. Also called the glutton, it takes various prey, from deer and hares to mice, as well as birds and eggs, and seasonal fruit. Active all year, it covers up to 31 miles (50 km) daily. The long, dense fur is blackish brown, with a pale brown band along each side, from the shoulder and flank over the rump to the base of the tail. There may be a white chest patch. The wolverine lives in a den among roots or rocks or dug 6½ ft (2 m) into a snowdrift. The litter size ranges between 1 and 5, although it is usually 2–4. The female suckles her young for 8–10 weeks.



Mellivora capensis

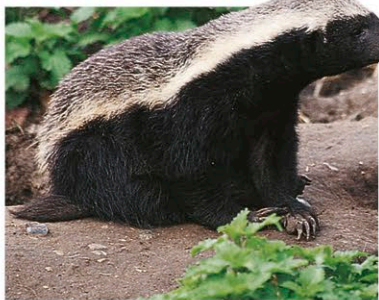
Honey badger



Location W., C., E., and southern Africa, W. and S. Asia



Length 29–38 in (73–96 cm)
Tail 5½–9 in (14–23 cm)
Weight 13½–30 lb (6.2–13.6 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern



The heavily built honey badger, or ratel, is silver-gray on the upper head, back, and tail, and black or dark brown elsewhere. Its long front claws are well-adapted for digging. The prey of this mustelid includes worms, termites, scorpions, porcupines, and hares. It also cooperates with the Greater honeyguide bird (see p.340), which leads it to bees' nests. The badger opens the nest to provide honey and grubs for both.

Meles meles

Eurasian badger



Location Europe to W. Asia



Length 22–35 in (56–90 cm)
Tail 4¾–8 in (12–20 cm)
Weight 22–35 lb (10–16 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern

One of the few group-dwelling mustelids, the Eurasian badger has a small, pointed head and short neck, widening to a powerful body, with short, strong limbs and a small tail. The underparts are black, the main body and tail gray, and the face and neck white, with a black stripe on each side, from the nose over the small eye to the ear. The sight of the Eurasian badger is poor, its hearing better, but it has a keen sense of smell. Nocturnal and omnivorous, this badger varies its diet with season and availability. Earthworms are a staple, supplemented by insects and grubs, as well as frogs, lizards, small mammals, birds and their eggs, carrion, fruit, and other plant matter. Inside the group's sett (see panel, above), the nests are lined with bedding of dry grass, leaves, and moss, which is changed regularly. After up to 10 months of delayed implantation (when the eggs are

COMMUNAL LIVING

Badgers in Britain form 6-member clans on average, although they can comprise up to 23 individuals. Elsewhere, they tend to live alone or in pairs. Their sett—an extensive system of tunnels and chambers—may have 10 or more entrances. Setts are kept clean, and are maintained and enlarged over many generations. Badgers range over a territory of 125–370 acres (50–150 hectares), which they defend against other clans.



fertilized but do not immediately implant into the uterine lining), and a gestation period of 7 weeks, the female gives birth to up to 6 cubs. She suckles them for 10 weeks.

VARIABLE STRIPE

The badger's distinctive striped face varies slightly between individuals. It may allow clan members to recognize each other or act as camouflage.

